

Victory... With A Twist

Adelaide Entertainment Centre, Adelaide, Australia

Danni was totally prepared. I was certain of it, all the way to my core. Our sessions had been sharp, and she seemed totally at ease. Steph, Mandy, Emma... I had grilled anyone who would have any insight at all into potential problems. Everyone agreed. Danni was ready.

So why was I tied up in knots?

Because this was MMA, and nothing is ever for certain. Especially against the likes of Julie Benz.

So, yeah... I was worried. But if those same prefight nerves were eating at Danni, she did a great job of hiding it.

Things are always crazy at an event, and Team is among the craziest. So, we didn't get much chance to talk, but I would catch sight of her here and there. Each time, she looked perfectly normal. Despite the fact that I try to pitch in and lighten the load when she's on the card, she just can't seem to slip out of stable leader mode. And that's what I saw. Her, focused on her teammates, with no signs of distraction.

As fight time drew near, she disappeared into the bowels of the trainer's area to get ready. I went from room-to-room until I found her, looking cool as a cucumber.

"How you feeling?" I asked.

"Fine," she answered, "but you're clearly a little worked up."

"What makes you say that?"

"Well, you felt the need to come check on me, for the first time ever."

Looking relaxed and giving me shit. Clearly, her confidence was high.

"I decided to make it a new tradition."

"Uh, huh."

"Don't make me slap you, OK?"

She smiled, I returned it, and I felt the bands constricting my chest release. Chance was chance. Random by definition. There was no point letting it torment me because you can only control so much, and we had done all we could do. Danni was as ready as she could be.

So, how did the fight go? Well, if your name happens to be Julie Benz, not so great.

I mean, she tried. She really did. There just wasn't anything she could do. Right out of the gate, the blonde surged forward behind her jab. Looking to take the fight right to Danni and force her to immediately answer the questions that had been swirling around her. That answer came in the form of a neat slip outside when Benz finally uncorked her right hand, then a vicious knee that drove Julie's chin straight up.

And that might have been the best moment Benz had all fight.

Despite the wicked impact, Julie impressed me by keeping the offense up - immediately countering with a combo designed to drive Danni away. The problem? She hit nothing but air because Danni had already retreated out of range.

The blonde kept coming, stepping into a body kick that Danni easily blocked.

Then it was Ms. Harris's turn. Exploiting Julie's miss, she pressed forward behind a pair of combos that Benz managed to partially absorb on her guard. Danni finished with a middle kick. Benz saw it, and easily got her arm down to block it. Except...

Danni's foot landed with such force that an audible CRACK echoed through the arena. Julie's face contorted in pain, and I swear I thought her arm was broken. She pushed past the pain and threw her guard back up, but Danni had already shifted strategies. She stepped in close and hooked her arms under Julie's. Then she put that newfound strength Steph mentioned to work and just plain muscled Benz into the fence.

Watching Julie struggle in Danni's grasp, I almost felt sorry for her. She tried to push back but got nowhere. Striking wasn't an option with her arms tied up and Danni pressed in close. Her only choice was to wait and see what Danni had planned, then try to react. It was a crappy option, and it worked about as well as you'd expect.

After grappling her opponent into the position she wanted, Danni released and threw a short left hook. Benz couldn't even see it coming until it was too late, and the punch landed flush on her cheek. After that came a chain of strikes from the taller brunette, with Benz continuously a step behind getting her defense in place. A right hand shot straight into Julie's nose. Danni moved to throw the left again, Benz cowered behind her guard and Danni changed targets... pushing a perfect kick into Benz's chest and crushing her against the mesh. The blonde's guard came down and Danni pulverized her with a left hook that opened up a nasty cut above her right eye. Benz wobbled right. When she got herself steadied, Danni was there - latching in the underhooks and smashing her up against the fence, again.

There was no grappling for position this time. Danni immediately let loose with a series of knees that pounded Julie's ribs and belly. Desperate to make it stop, Benz brought her leg up and her elbow down to close the hole in her defense. No problem. Danni simply went to town on her now unprotected face.

Left hook-straight right-left hook.

All of them landed before Julie could even react. Blood streamed from her nose and a second cut had opened under her left eye. She hid behind her guard again, and Danni shifted her attention back down with a pair of hooks to the gut. It was so easy, she looked she was working the heavy bag back at the gym. Benz seemed to sense

the desperate position she was in and launched a hell-or-high-water combo that was all power and zero technique.

Left-right-left-right-left-right-uppercut.

Nothing. Danni's defense was so perfect, it looked like she was reading her opponent's thoughts. And when she pulled her head out and let the uppercut sail by, everyone in the arena knew Julie's night was over.

Danni wove back in behind a vicious left hand, then squared up for the finale.

Right hook-left hook-right uppercut.

Goodnight, Julie.

The ref jumped in as Benz collapsed. Danni retreated to the opposite corner, making way as the medics poured in. Julie's team was next, with Steph and Marcy behind them. They went straight to Danni, and the three engaged in subdued conversation as a flurry of activity erupted around Benz. After an agonizing thirty seconds or so, Julie started to move. Shortly thereafter, the crowd around her thinned and she sat up. That's when the smiles broke out on the RSI side.

By the time the official announcement was made, I was waiting in the locker room. When Danni came in, her teammates mobbed her, as expected. Then they seemed to become aware that I was waiting and parted like the Red Sea.

I know I should have played it cool with everyone watching, but I couldn't help myself. I walked straight through the crowd and threw my arms around her, trapping her own arms at her sides.

She looked at me and smiled.

"Guess I did okay, huh?"

"Eh, not bad," I smiled back.

Exactly how good was she? Well, for those who lost count, allow me to summarize.

Danni hit Julie with everything but the kitchen sink. The official tally would show she scored with an impressive eighty percent of the strikes she threw. The price for exacting such brutality? None. Not even so much as a scratch. In a fight that lasted just over three and a half minutes, Benz was never able to beat Danni's defense and land a clean shot.

And that, ladies and gentlemen, is how you silence the doubters.

There was little time to savor the victory, though. With three teams comprised of a total of twenty-four fighters, we had a lot going on. And, when the hugs and high-fives were all over, it was time for one of our legendary debriefs.

How did they become legendary? Well, it all started with such a simple idea. A year or so ago, I decided to do away with the typical post-event article for these team events. With so many fighters in action, it just didn't make sense. Instead, I would hold a live round-table with Danni, Steph and the respective team leaders, then have the whole thing transcribed and let that serve as RSI's magazine contribution.

Genius, right?

Well, then the team leaders got to thinking they would each pick a Fighter of the Night and bring that individual to the session, too.

Fair enough.

Then they had trouble choosing, so they started bringing extra people.

Hey... hold on a second.

This time around... well, I had a plan before it started, anyway. Despite the fact that I couldn't stop thinking about it, I was determined not to focus on Danni's win. Her performance had been practically flawless, which, as far as I'm concerned, is exactly what she normally does. Maybe others had questions about her, but, here at RSI, we knew the real Danni and that's what we got tonight. Ho-hum. Par for the course. Next question, please. Anything more would only lend credence to the whispers.

Lucky for me, tonight had been a banner night for us. Britney and Elisha's groups had dropped only a few fights between them, while Aly's crew had cleaned house. So, I expected to have plenty of non-Danni topics to keep me busy.

Turns out, I got a lot more than I bargained for.

The problem? With so many great performances, my fearless leaders had trouble picking their top-performers.

The solution? They just brought everybody.

Three teams. Twenty-four total fighters. Plus me.

Oy vey.

It took us half an hour to find a room big enough to fit everybody. Once we got settled... well, with so many varied and outsized personalities, insanity was bound to ensue. But it was the little twist at the end that became the craziest moment of all.

The RSI teams had a night for the record books here in Adelaide, including one that achieved a feat most would say was impossible. Team leaders Britney Spears, Elisha Cuthbert and Alyson Michalka are here with me. They're supposed to help me make sense of things, but instead they have wreaked havoc upon the process. Each was supposed to bring along her choice for Fighter of the Night, but Aly couldn't choose. She wanted to bring three fighters with her. That led to Britney asking if she could bring more, and the whole thing devolved into predictable chaos. The end result? Everyone is here. Everyone. I am surrounded by twenty-four fighters, seated at a table so large that the opposing ends are in different time zones. Among the group are RSI leader Danneel Harris and fighter development coordinator Stephanie McMahon. The two I am counting on most to help me keep this thing under control. Do you think it will work? Me neither, but here goes...

Richelle Winterfeld: No point in beating around the bush on this one. This event was a tremendous success for RSI, up and down the board. I have never been as proud of all of you as I am, tonight. Leesh, that means you need to pick your head up right now.

Elisha Cuthbert: I appreciate you trying to help, but...

Richelle: I know. You dropped another tough one - to former stablemate Anna Silk, this time. But you used to train together. She knows you.

Elisha: I should know her, too.

Richelle: *(shrugs)* Somebody has to lose. It just wasn't your night.

Elisha: That seems to happen to me a lot.

Richelle: *(sighs as she motions to Britney)* Can you fix this?

Britney Spears: Eventually. Not right now, though.

Richelle: OK, we'll come back to it. But Alyson... I really have no choice but to lead this one off with your group. Many of the teams are made up of fighters of mixed experience, and you guys are no exception to that. With three relatively new fighters on your roster, things are always a grind for you guys. It goes without saying that I have been impressed with what you guys have accomplished from the very beginning. But nothing... absolutely nothing... could have prepared me for this. On a night when you were up against one of the most experienced teams in the competition, you accomplished the rare feat of absolute perfection. So, don't take this the wrong way, but... how in the hell did you do this?

Alyson Michalka: Wasn't me. I just did my part. Ash, Emma, Danni, J-Law... they all did their thing against tough opponents, too. But the key to victory was these three ladies, right here.
Britney Spears

(Aly gestures to the three women to her right - Brittany Tacy, Marzia Prince and Allira Cohrs)

Richelle: Well, what of it, ladies? Each of you had to face an opponent with more than triple your experience, yet all three of you not only won but did so convincingly. What was the secret to this astonishing result?

(The three women exchange shrugs and unsure looks until Marzia takes the initiative)

Marzia Prince: Well, for me, I think it was fear of death.

Brittany Tacy: *(laughing)* I think that's right. I think we all just worried about staying in one piece.

Allira Cohrs: *(nods)* All I could think about was keeping Uma in front of me and keeping my guard up.

Richelle: Survival is a powerful motivator, I'm sure. But you guys didn't exactly look afraid out there. Any insights, Ms. McMahon?

Stephanie McMahon: Normally, a fight like this... you'll see the younger fighter come in keyed up. Like she knows she has to be perfect, and she's rehearsing all her moves in her head. But they weren't like that, at all. They came in loose, and they stayed that way. Tacy and Cohrs paid close attention during the breaks, and they did what I asked. Prince didn't even get that far. The point is, they didn't let the moment overtake them. All three acted like they had nothing to lose and everything to gain.

Richelle: These were huge fights for you guys. How'd you stay so relaxed?

Allira: That was Aly.

Richelle: Oh?

Marzia: Yep. She's been working on us for weeks.

Richelle: Working on you, how?

Marzia: 'Fight your way, not hers.'

Brittany: 'Keep the fight in front of you.'

Allira: 'Stay smart, and take what she gives you.'

Richelle: *(grinning at Aly)* You said those things?

Aly: *(shrugs)* I didn't want them thinking too much.

Brittany: She wouldn't even let us watch film.

Richelle: That true?

Aly: *(shrugs again)* There was no point. They couldn't game plan for everything their opponents could do. It was better just to focus on making themselves better.

Stephanie: Which is why they didn't feel the need to be perfect. They just went out there and did their thing.

Richelle: What are you trying to say, Steph?

Stephanie: I'm saying the one who was perfect was Aly. She knew what her fighters could do, and what they couldn't. She kept them focused on the could, and she didn't let them dwell on the other stuff. They were as prepared as they could be for tonight. Both physically and mentally.

Richelle: *(Turns to Danni in mild shock.)* Did you hear that?

Danneel Harris: I did.

Richelle: You ever hear something like that from her before?

Danni: Never.

Richelle: You hear that, Aly? Never.

Aly: I am truly speechless.

Stephanie: You deserve it. These three matchups... the odds were not in your favor. But you pulled it off.

Danni: I agree. You kept your fighters focused and positive at a time when it was easy to slip into a panic.

Richelle: Well, I'm proud of all of you. Brittany, Marzia, Allira... what you did was amazing. I never want to sell a fighter short, but this was beyond anything I could have imagined. But let's not overlook the rest. Tiz, Danni, Jen, Aly... these were not easy fights for any of you, but you all came ready to...

Emma Watson: Pardon me, but aren't you forgetting someone?

Richelle: Yeah, yeah. You were good, too.

Emma: Nice. That's real nice.

Richelle: OK Brit, you're gang is up. Only one loss for you guys, so Kelly, we'll start with you against Kate Lawler.

Kelly Hu: It's a tough one to swallow. I was expecting a war with Kate, and that's what I was getting. Then she caught me with that right, and the blood was too much for the ref to take. I think it was crap. I mean, stopping it for a cut nose? How often does that happen? But, whatever... it's just disappointing. I trained a long time to be ready, and I would have liked the chance to fight it out with her.

Richelle: I hear you, but, honestly, the nose looked pretty bad at the time. And it means you'll have to sit out the upcoming tournament.

Kelly: True, but I'm still more bummed about tonight. My last fight with Kate was great, but it ended pretty shitty. I was looking forward to getting another shot at her.

Danni: Yeah... I know you were. I'm sure this won't be your last chance, though.

Richelle: No doubt. In the meantime, why don't we run through the rest of the fights? Kristen... Annie Short isn't all that experienced, but she hung in there pretty well.

Kristen Bell: RWB is known for being tough, and full of surprises. I was just glad to get the win.

Richelle: Emily, Pippa Middleton may be near-royalty, but she's certainly not soft in the cage.

Emily VanCamp: Not at all. She put up quite a fight. I'm happy with the victory, but I feel bad about the way it ended.

Stephanie: Word is that her leg isn't too serious. She's gonna need some time, though.

Danni: Steph, how is it you know everything? Where do you get the 'word' from? It's not even our stable.

Stephanie: It's my job to know what's going on.

Richelle: And you do it quite well... even if a bit mysteriously. Amanda... Chloe Saxon gave you all you could handle, with nearly a full round spent on the ground.

Amanda Seyfried: Not my favorite place to be.

Stephanie: And yet, you turned it around on her every time. You're ground game is much better than you give yourself credit for.

Richelle: *(Gives Steph a sideways glance)* Alright, what is going on with you? I've never seen you this nice.

Stephanie: I don't think I've ever been in this good a mood before.

Danni: Yeah. Things went so well, she has hardly anything to complain about.

Richelle: This is unheard of. I don't even know what to say.

Stephanie: Just try not to ruin it.

Richelle: Fair enough. Well Mandy, Steph is right. Chloe was able to get what she wanted a few times, but it did her no good. And you did more than just tie her up, too. You did a little damage on the canvas.

Amanda: I was tired of my ground work being such a big weakness, so I've been working on it.

Richelle: Well, it certainly paid off. That brings us to you and Jennifer Metcalf, Brit.

Britney: Not much to say. I felt good going in, and everything just clicked. Some nights, you just feel unbeatable.

Richelle: True enough. Looked like you were feeling pretty good too, Krystal. You certainly put on a display against Jodie Gasson.

Krystal Forscutt: Jodie's situation is a lot like mine. She had her ups and downs. But when she gets going, she can rip your head off. I wanted to keep her off balance, and luckily I was able to do that.

Krystal Forscutt

Richelle: It looked like more than luck to me. Mac, that brings us to you. Keely Hazell hasn't had much success against the better fighters, and she didn't fare too well against you, either.

Catherine Bell: She's tough as nails, though. I mean, I beat the hell out of her, and she just kept coming. I have a lot of respect for that. Things may not come easily to her, but you can't say it's because she doesn't try.

Richelle: I agree. The way she kept getting back up was unbelievable. Well last, but never least, Ms. Stephanie. With Alice Goodwin sidelined, we didn't know until late who were going to draw. Getting Abi Titmuss was probably not a pleasant surprise, but it didn't seem to phase you, at all.

Danni: Yeah, Steph. You seemed a little... motivated.

Stephanie: Been doing a lot of losing, lately. So, it's possible I may have been a little bit pissed off, yeah.

Richelle: Emotion is usually a problem in that cage. However, it seemed Abi was the one with all the problems in this one.

Danni: Well, that's what happens when Steph gets pissed.

Stephanie: That had nothing to do with it. Abi is not someone you fuck around with. When I saw my chance, I took it. Yeah, it got bad for her, but she's been around long enough to know that's how it goes, sometimes. Last time we met, she dropped me like a sack of meat within seconds. So, she knows.

Richelle: *(to Danni)* 'Like a sack of meat,' she says.

Danni: Her imaginative descriptions are almost like poetry.

Steph: OK, remember what I said? You're ruining it.

Richelle: Leesh, that brings us back to you. I know you had a tough night personally, but, as a whole, you're team was pretty good.

Elisha: They did. Which was good, since some of us couldn't pull our own weight.

Richelle: Of course, success should be expected against a younger team like the one you faced.

Tiffany Mulheron: Hey, wait a second. That's not fair.

Daniela Hantuchova: This is not right way to see it. They are always tough, these Bunnies.

Richelle: Aww, c'mon. Half the team is inexperienced, and they had to pull Capri Anderson off the bench to fill in for the more seasoned Kloe Kardashian. How tough could they be?

Julianne Hough: Are you kidding? Have you been paying any attention to the way they've been winning? I mean, if the team is so bad, then why are they ranked so highly?

Richelle: *(shrugs)* They've been feeding on the lower ranked teams.

Petra Cubonova: This is crazy talk. Is because they are good, is why.

Torrie Wilson: Damn right, that's why. Their prep work is second to none. So, you're right... they should be easy to beat. They shouldn't be able to win the way they do. But the Bunnies don't give a shit. They always think they can win.

Richelle: I don't know. I mean, you guys did well, but in the face of what Aly's group did... it feels like you're making a big deal out of nothing.

Roselyn Sanchez: How can you say that? *¿Has perdido la cabeza? ¡Un error, y esas chicas te va a matar! ¡Van a aplastar como a un insecto!*

Richelle: OK, OK... there's no need to go all *esta loca* on me, Roz. I think you guys are making my point for me. I mean, why are you getting so defensive?

Cobie Smulders: Because you're basically attacking us.

Julianne: Yeah... I don't care who we faced. We worked our asses off to be ready.

Richelle: I'm not denying that. I'm just...

Elisha: ENOUGH!

(The conversation halts as all eyes turn to Elisha, who has her focus squarely and intently on Richelle.)

Richelle: Got something to say, Leesh?

Elisha: I'm not gonna let you talk to them this way. They've worked too hard for too long, and I'm not gonna let you trivialize that.

Richelle: *(turns to Danni)* Wow. 'Trivialize.' Big word.

Danni: Oh, no you don't. Don't you drag me into your little game.

Elisha: *(ignoring the banter)* You're right. This was one they were supposed to win. And they did. But don't make it sound like it was easy. Training is always a grind, and having to do it for a fight you're supposed to win makes it worse.

Richelle: You're going to whine to me about training, now?

Elisha: I'm not whining. I'm saying don't give me bullshit about easy. Jayde Nicole, Jessica Ashley... those girls have been making a career of winning fights they were supposed to lose.

Richelle: What's your point?

Elisha: That you're turning what my team accomplished into a footnote. I mean, why did they even bother? If they'd lost, it would have been a big disappointment. But they win, and all you can say is they weren't a disappointment?

Richelle: OK... I guess I really hadn't thought about it that way.

Elisha: Damn right, you didn't. And I'm really surprised. Stuff like this... when there's so much risk with so little reward... you usually do a better job of showing the fighters your appreciation.

Richelle: You're right. I'm sorry.

Tiffany: I have to be honest, Leesh... I don't think most of us had that hard a time getting ready.

Daniela: Yes... was not bad. Maybe because is not about us?

Elisha: Not about us?

Richelle: I think maybe Daniela is saying this one was about the team, and not about each of you individually.

Daniela: Yes... this is what I say. Is bigger this way.

Torrie: That's true I think. These team events... I don't focus on what I get out of it. It means more to do my part for the team. I don't care if people are impressed by my performance.

Julianne: Plus, you know your teammates are going to appreciate it when you win.

Petra: And be there when you lose, ya?

Britney: *(nudges Elisha with her elbow)* Is true, ya?

Elisha: Yeah, I guess.

Petra: *(shakes her head at Britney)* Do not do this. You're accent... it is terrible.

Richelle: It's funny that you guys feel this way. Even though it's a team event, your performances are still individual.

Cobie: That's not really true.

Richelle: How so?

Cobie: I don't know. It just feels different. I mean, yeah... you fight on your own, but you know it's part of something else. That you're part of something else.

Tiffany: Plus, you're not on your own. The whole team is out there. You see them during the round breaks. You hear them when you're fighting.

Richelle: So, you're telling me that while you were battling it out with Capri Anderson... a fighter with almost no experience and not that great of a record... when she was still standing there giving you all she had in that third round, having your teammates behind you made a difference?

Tiffany: Yes.

Richelle: You're a sitting champion. If you had lost that fight, it would have been quite an embarrassment.

Tiffany: Never thought about that. I was just worried about letting the team down.

Richelle: Seems like quite a tight-knit group. And I'm going to say it again... there's no reason why it has to be that way. You each have your own career to worry about. So, I'm wondering how this happened.

Torrie: It's always been like this. When these events come up, we meet as a team. Leesh brings us together to train as a team. We even watch film as a team.

Julianne: Actually, we do everything as a team. We all know who our opponents are. We know what challenges each one of us faces. We even help gameplan for each other.

Richelle: Sounds like quite a setup. *(focuses on Elisha)* Especially coming from someone who failed to pull her weight.

Tiffany: Ohhh... now I see what you're up to.

Elisha: Nice try. But you know what I was talking about.

Richelle: Ohhh, ladies... I think your leader needs a hug.

Torrie: *(starts to rise)* Awww... poor Leesh.

Elisha: No, no, no... I'm fine.

(The 7 members of Elisha's team get up from various points around the table and gravitate towards Elisha)

Elisha: Awww, c'mon... don't...

(Tiffany arrives first and loops her arms around Elisha's neck from behind. The others gather quickly, draping their arms around each other until the team is assembled en masse around their leader. Elisha puts on an exaggerated look of defeated surrender which does nothing to hide the little smile that has crept onto her face)

Richelle: You've been having a tough time, Leesh. Losing sucks, no two ways about it. But everyone in this room knows how it feels. In the meantime, you are the center of this team. You pull your weight and then some. So, enough of that shit, OK?

Elisha: If I say yes, will you get them off of me?

(The group laughs, then the women slowly head back to their seats.)

Richelle: Alright, ladies... Operation Snap Leesh Out of It was a success, but it took up a lot of time. So, instead of going through the fights in detail, just give me one word each to describe your opponent for the evening.

Julianne: Unstoppable.

Tiffany: Tenacious.

Roselyn: *En fuego.*

Cobie: Fast.

Elisha: Mistake.

Richelle: I assume you're aiming that one at me for letting her go. And I admit, you may well be right. How about you, Daniela?

Daniela: Confidence.

Petra: Future.

Richelle: Future?

Petra: Yes. I believe she will be much better, in future.

Richelle: Ah... so, like... 'future superstar.' I got it. And you, Torrie?

Torrie: Stupid.

Richelle: I'm sorry... I think you're gonna have to explain that one.

Torrie: As in, she's too stupid to know she shouldn't be able to do the things she's been doing.

Steph: I warned you about that. Ashley tore it up all of last year. Then, she opens this year with probably the biggest win of her career. So, not only does she have the skills, but she came in with all the confidence in the world. She doesn't give a shit what she should or shouldn't be able to do. A young fighter like that given the chance to knock off a sitting champion? I told you she was gonna make you earn it.

Torrie: She sure did. Jessica pushed the fight deep into the third round, and never showed an ounce of fear. She was really taking it to me up until those last few minutes. I was a mess by the time it was over.

Richelle: But a happy mess. And Trish and the medical team seem to have patched you up pretty good.

Torrie: They're good at what they do. Plus, winning does a lot to dull the pain.

Richelle: Well, a job well done, ladies. All the way around, I'm a very happy owner today. Meanwhile, that's all for this event. Next up is the Red Carpet tournament, where RSI has twenty-three fighters seeded. With the likes of Emily VanCamp, Tiffany Mulheron and Danni Harris...

Emma: And me.

Richelle: You've never won one of these things.

Emma: Then I'm due.

Tiffany: *(with a wry smile)* Unless your girlfriend flattens you, again.

Emma: Shut up.

Richelle: OK, then... with Emily, Danni, Tiff, Aly... RSI has quite a list of fighters capable of bringing home a title. And there's always at least one crazy result at these tournaments, so who knows? Maybe Emma can win one, too.

Emma: Now see, why can't you be nicer to me?

Richelle: Because annoying the shit out of you is so much fun?

Emma: That's just not right. How would you feel if I treated you this way?

Richelle: Uhm... you do treat me this way.

Emma: Oh, yeah... that's right. Well, carry on, then.

Richelle: That's all for this one, folks. We'll see you next time in Perth, as the league's tour of the Land Down Under continues.

Though it seemed like our usual banter, something about Emma's tone caught my attention. As the group broke up, I noticed she was quick to make her escape, rather than spending time chatting with her teammates.

"I think you pushed it too far, this time," Danni said from beside me.

"Did I say something that was out of line?"

She shrugged.

"Didn't seem like it to me, but it's not my opinion that matters."

I caught Tiffany's attention and motioned her over.

"Something going on with Em?"

"I think so," she said. "She's been talking about the tournament for about a week, now. I think she's tired of being seen as second level. She wants this thing, bad."

Though Emma has long been the champion of her weight class, that particular group is viewed as somewhat weak, overall. While Victoria Justice and Xenia Deli are quickly proving they've got what it takes, experts and fans alike often view Emma as untested. Her teammates and I know better, but it's only the league-wide events like the upcoming tournament where she gets to prove it. To date, she has done very well... even advancing to the final of this tournament last year. But she has yet to win it all on the bigger stage.

I've never given that fact any thought before. It's not something to worry about because I know it's only a matter of time.

Apparently, Emma wanted that time to be now.

"I'll talk to her," I said.

I started toward the door, but Tiff stopped me.

"I think you kinda ticked her off," she said. "I might give her a little time."

I turned to her and let my confusion show through. The brief exchange at the end was nothing new for Emma and I. Had it really bothered her that much?

Before I had the chance to say anything, Danni stepped forward.

"I'll go," she said.

My initial instinct was to protest. I hadn't meant to insult Emma, and, if I had, I wanted to set it right. But it only took a moment to remind myself that Danni was as capable of handling the situation as I was. Maybe more so, if Emma was really angry with me.

I nodded, and Danni went after Emma. Meanwhile, I just stood there and stewed. Playing back the earlier conversation to see if I had said something truly stupid.

"She's not really mad," Tiffany said.

"Huh?"

"Emma," she said. "She's not really mad at you."

"Then, why..."

Tiff motioned with her head toward the windows that looked out onto the hallway. Danni had already caught up to Emma, and the two were involved in a serious-looking discussion.

I took a few seconds to process the situation.

"She wanted Danni?"

Tiffany nodded, and I spent another moment or two working things out.

Emma wanted Danni, specifically. Why?

Something I did? That didn't seem right, and Tiff just said she wasn't really angry.

Something about Danni, then. Some reason...

"You guys are up to something," I said as it started to come together.

"Who? Us?" she said too innocently.

I just kept my eyes on her and waited for more.

"We've all been talking," she began. "We enjoyed being able to return some of what Danni has given us these past few weeks. We really want to keep it going, but we know she's been sort of letting us get away with it. That she doesn't really like being the center of attention."

I nodded, though I wasn't sure it was entirely true. While it's true Danni hates attention, she definitely seemed to enjoy going at it with her more accomplished teammates.

"So, we're thinking maybe there's a better way," Tiff continued. "Maybe help her by letting her help us."

"And that's where Emma comes in."

"To some degree," Tiff said.

"And what does that mean?"

"It means Emma may be playing it up, but it's not really an act," she answered. "She wants to win this thing, and she thinks Danni can help."

There was no arguing that point. Getting a little extra education from Danni could be exactly what Emma needs to push her over the top. Especially considering how close she's already come.

That thought led me to muse about who it was that had ended her run last time. I didn't have to think hard or look very far.

"If she's going to win it, she'll likely have to go through you," I said.

The blonde shrugged.

"That's part of the deal," she said. "I stopped her last time. It wasn't fun, but it's what we agreed to. We knew these moments would happen."

Despite the fact that I knew what her answer would be, it was still hard for me to accept. It's hard enough to compete against a teammate, but to have to fight someone so close to you?

I shook my head. It makes me thankful that Danni and I never have to go beyond sparring.

"So, what's the plan?" I asked. "I mean, this gets Emma involved, but it sounds like all of you want to be a part of it."

"Hmm," she said suspiciously, "let's just see what develops."

The whole idea probably should have given me pause. After all, Emma wasn't the only one who needed a big performance at the upcoming tournament. Despite the dominant win over Benz, Danni still had things to prove. And the best of the best usually rise to the top in the tournament format, meaning she was likely to find herself in the cage with a number of dangerous opponents. Now, more than ever, she needed to buckle down and get to work. It was not the time to be distracted by fooling around with Emma and the others.

But the little voice inside me said I should let this play out. Danni's teammates knew the stakes as well as I did, and they would never do anything that might jeopardize her chances. And I could still use our evening sessions as a barometer. If it seemed she was losing her edge, I could always step in then.

Above all, there was something that felt right about putting Danni in the capable hands of the women she leads. They had done so much for her already, they wanted to do more, and they seemed to be getting something out of it themselves.

I couldn't imagine a better way for the stable to run.

"Let me know if I can help," I said.